Key question
How was the Egyptian monarchy overthrown?

Nasser and the Egyptian revolution

Gamal Abdul Nasser was one of a number of young officers who came from a poor background but had received an education and risen up through the ranks of the army. A group of these young officers, who called themselves the Free Officers, secretly plotted to overthrow the government. They took their time, building up support within the army while avoiding being uncovered or captured by the security police. In July 1952, they struck. They took over the key government buildings and announced the success of the revolution over the radio. They allowed the King to flee the country. He had lost much respect, especially after divorcing his popular Egyptian wife and spending much of his time in expensive European resorts on the Mediterranean.

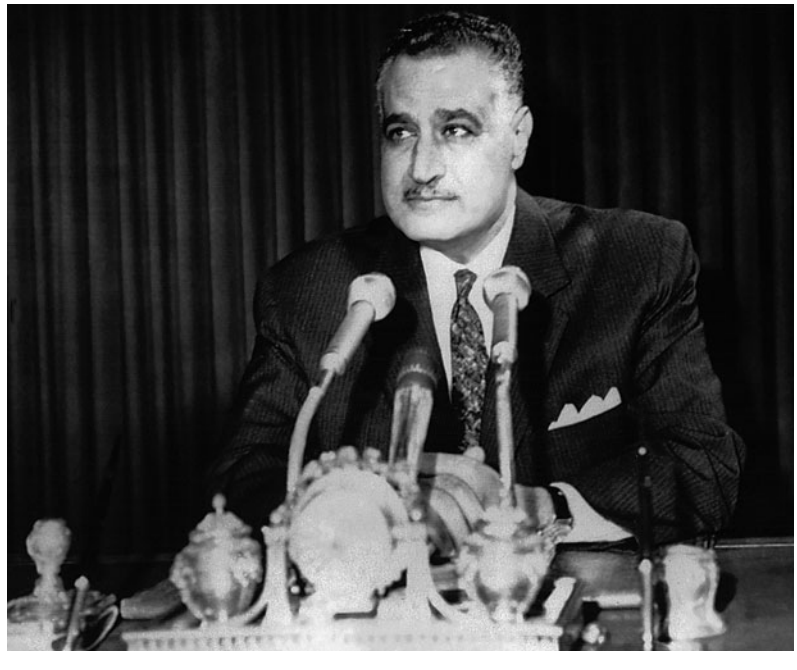
Key dates
King of Egypt overthrown by army officers: 1952

Nasser became President of Egypt: 1954

The head of the new government was General Neguib, one of the more respected of the senior army officers and, when Egypt became a republic in 1953, he became President. However, the most powerful member of the new government was Colonel Nasser. He had never forgotten the dying words of a comrade in the 1948–9 war: 'Remember the real battle is in Egypt.' He believed the first part of this battle had now been won with the removal of the King's government. The second part was to make his country truly independent and that meant freeing Egypt of foreign (i.e. British) troops.

Key term
Soviet Union
The name by which communist Russia was known from 1917 to 1991. Its official name was the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR).

In 1954 Nasser became president and, after long discussions, he persuaded the British to withdraw their troops from the Suez Canal zone. Britain, like the USA, still wished to keep on good terms with Nasser. They wanted Arab support in the Middle East against the **Soviet Union**. They wanted an alliance with Egypt as it was the strongest, most developed Arab nation and because the Suez Canal passed through its territory.



Colonel Nasser was one of the army officers who overthrew the unpopular royal government of Egypt in 1952. In 1954 he became President of Egypt.